most tellingly—the party eventually won all its four Lok Sabha seats from Punjab.

Amritsar, though, was just one out of 543 seats in the country. The overwhelming feedback elsewhere was of a rising Modi wave. A desperate Congress was in a state of utter despair. An attempt was made to get Sonia Gandhi to campaign a bit more aggressively. Sonia had, perhaps consciously, chosen to take a backseat in the election build-up. This, after all, was supposed to be Rahul's moment in the political sun. Her long-serving aides like Ahmed Patel and Ghulam Nabi Azad were already feeling sidelined by Team Rahul. Patel had direct access to Sonia and could virtually walk in and out of 10, Janpath. 12, Tughlaq Lane, Rahul's office-cum-residence, was different. Here, Patel had to ask for time and was kept out of key elements of the campaign strategy. When I asked him about it, he denied having differences with Rahul. 'He is our leader,' was the cryptic response. Truth is, there was an acute generation gap. Patel and Azad, both veteran crisis managers for the party, had been contemporaries of Rajiv. There was a communication issue too—one sensed that Rahul was more comfortable with the English-speaking politicians who shared his political beliefs. 'I think he has a disdain for a particular type of Congress politician. Maybe he sees them as oily dealmakers,' is how someone who knows Rahul well described his attitude to the party's old guard.

Aware that Rahul was not being able to challenge Modi on his own, Sonia decided to step up her assault on the BJP leader. She probably still had more spunk left in her than her son. 'She is the only real politician left in the party,' is how a Sonia loyalist put it to me. One April evening, just as I was going into the 9 p.m. bulletin, my Congress correspondent Pallavi Ghosh sent me an SMS. 'Sonia is going to make an address to the nation on TV shortly. It could be important.' On the face of it, it seemed a bit odd—nationally televised addresses are normally made only by the prime minister or the president of India, not by the Congress president. Would Sonia make a dramatic announcement that she, and not Rahul, would now lead the Congress charge in the final phase?